



overseas to find out Mumbai's progress in the Ranji Trophy, and right from the moment he answered the phone, I would know whether Mumbai had done well or was struggling.

I remember dedicating my century at Adelaide in 1985 to him because he had just had a successful bypass surgery. He had another bypass surgery a decade or so later, but his heart had weakened considerably, though he never ever showed it or made any fuss about it. He fulfilled many roles for Tatas and Mumbai, being a selector, manager, and, in recent times, also an advisor to the Mumbai Cricket Association.

Right till the end, he was obsessed with Mumbai cricket, and even in the hospital, he was glued to Mumbai's progress. The disappointing loss in the semis would certainly have demoralised and dejected him, and that's the sad thing — that he went knowing that Mumbai was not going to be in the final. They say that

Strong bond: Sunil Gavaskar (foreground) and Milind Rege (holding trophy) knew each other since infancy and were best friends ever since.

THE HINDU PHOTO LIBRARY

friends are your greatest wealth, and in his leaving, I have become enormously poorer. I am sure, from up there, he will be checking up on what's happening in the Tatas as well as Mumbai cricket circles and wanting them to do well.

It was very nice to know of the respect shown by the Mumbai team, observing two minutes' silence once the news of his passing away came through.

While this has been sad news, the good news is India beating Pakistan and ensuring a place for themselves in the semi-final. It has been a superb all-round show, which gives us hope that they will be able to go all the way and bring the Champions Trophy back home.

I used to call Milind regularly from overseas to find out Mumbai's progress in the Ranji Trophy, and right from the moment he answered the phone, I would know whether Mumbai had done well or if Mumbai was struggling.